Former Teachers: Barriers, Incentives and Policy Lessons for Re-entry

Directorate for Education and Skills

WORKING DRAFT

Abstract

Résumé

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1. Introduction

Pendiente de escribir (al final de todo). Yo creo que aquí es clave resaltar los aprendizajes y que alguien que lea esto se quede con todo lo importante. Si alguien quiere detalles de research, que pueda pasar a la sección 2, y si quieren solo policy que pasen a 3.

Re-attracting former teachers has become one of the policy margins through which governments are trying to alleviate the current problem of teacher shortages. Although not sufficient to close the gap on its own, it can help reduce and fill vacancies in the short run, especially in the disadvantaged and rural schools where shortages tend to concentrate (UNESCO, 2024; Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2019; Nguyen, Lam and Bruno, 2024). The magnitude of this policy margin depends on the baseline leaving and retirement rates, since in countries such as France, Greece, Ireland or Israel, whose low leaving rates are almost solely explained by retirement, its potential is scarce (OECD, 2025a). Beyond short-run relief to shortages, returners and retired teachers can bring benefits of their own, such as positive experience spillovers to colleagues, mentorship for beginning teachers and tutoring roles with experimental backing (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017; Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024).

2. Teacher leaving: rates, determinants and implications for re-entry

To design and evaluate the impact of policies that aim to bring former teachers back to the classroom it is fundamental to have a thorough understanding of the reasons why teachers leave. Moreover, it is crucial to identify the experiences and added value that former teachers can bring back to educational systems if they are successfully reintegrated. This debate is of central importance for governments that are making a wide range of efforts to retain and re-attract former teachers in response to the pressing challenges of an ageing teaching workforce, serious teacher shortages and the rising concerns over teachers' burnout and lack of mentorship (OECD, 2025a; UNESCO, 2024; Madigan and Kim, 2021; OECD, 2025b). This section therefore reviews what is known about why teachers leave, before the paper turns to the policies that have tried to bring them back.

First, we distinguish three main profiles of former teachers: (1) switchers, those who resign from teaching to take up other part-time or full-time employment, (2) leavers, those who withdraw from the labour market, and (3) retired teachers who have reached the end of their working lives. The determinants of leaving and the opportunity cost that each group faces when considering whether to re-enter vary significantly across these profiles. As the evidence reviewed in this section shows, switchers leave mainly over the conditions of the job and the standing of the profession, and pay weighs less in their decision than is often assumed; leavers leave for reasons that lie outside the school, mostly family and health, and respond above all to flexibility; and retired teachers leave when pension rules make it worthwhile, and are kept out of the classroom by those same rules once they have retired.

These institutional factors are nonetheless highly country-dependent, and a comprehensive description would require a paper of its own. Here we instead, we first describe the evolution and scope of the teacher leaving rate and posteriorly develop a general framework that classifies the most common motives for leaving and illustrates them with selected country examples. Each area of reasons closes with its implications for re-entry and with the profile it mainly concerns, and Box 1 at the end of the section brings them together.

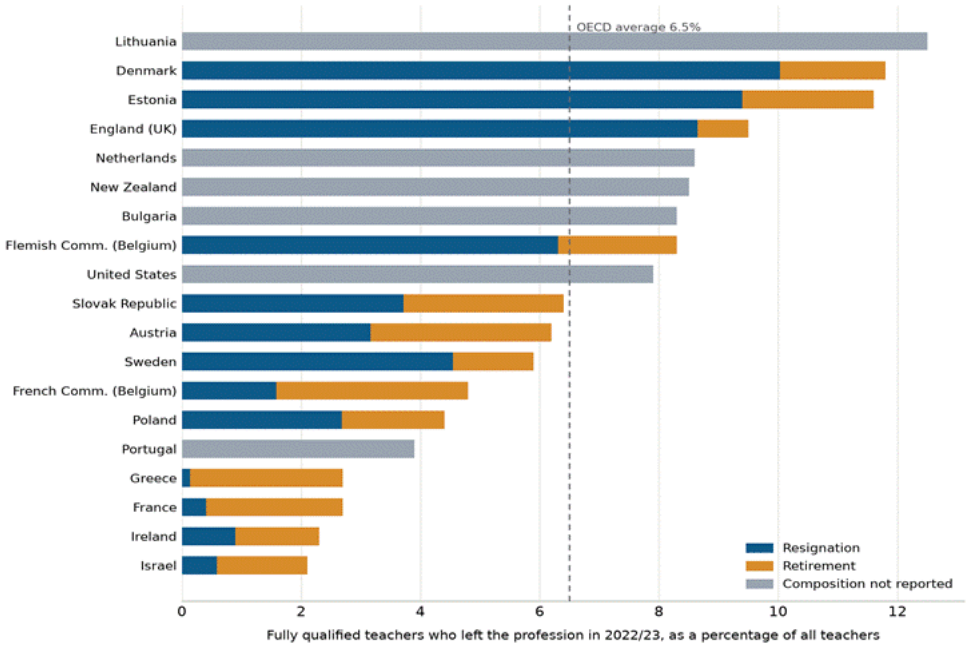
2.1 The teacher leaving rate and its evolution

The average teacher leaving rate across OECD countries was 6.5% in 2023, with considerable differences among the countries with available data (OECD, 2025a; see Figure 1). In countries with rates close to 2%, such as Israel, Ireland, France and Greece, the workforce renews itself through retirement

alone. In countries with higher rates, such as Lithuania, Denmark or Estonia, a larger share of departures corresponds to leavers and switchers. These systems must replace a substantial part of their stock every year, which raises questions about working conditions and retention.

The evolution of the leaving rate across time tends to be stable in most of the observed countries. The OECD average leaving rate moved from 6.9% in 2015 to 6.5% in 2023 and most systems present in both years moved by less than a percentage point (OECD, 2025a). Moreover, studies developed in countries with the longest available series confirm this stable trend. In USA, which holds one of the longest-running national series, the rate has oscillated between 5% and 8.5% across three and a half decades of survey waves, has sat near 8% for the last twenty years, and carries no lasting mark from the pandemic increase (NCES, 2024), and similar patterns hold in England, New Zealand, Sweden, Israel, Iceland, Norway and Flanders (Department for Education, 2024a; Education Counts, 2025; Adermon and Laun, 2018; CBS Israel, 2023; Björnsdóttir and Hansen, 2024; Statistics Norway, 2025; Vansteenkiste, 2025).

Figure 1. The teacher leaving rate and its composition, 2022/23



Note: Share of fully qualified teachers, full-time and part-time in public institutions, who left the profession during the reference year, from pre-primary to upper secondary education. The split into resignations and retirements is shown where reported; grey bars report the total rate only. The OECD average refers to the 19 countries and economies with available data. The reference year differs from 2022/23 for Denmark, France, New Zealand and England (2021/22). Data refer to primary and lower secondary education combined and exclude upper secondary education in Denmark, exclude upper secondary education in Israel and upper secondary vocational education in the Netherlands, and include non-fully qualified teachers in the Netherlands, New Zealand and the Flemish Community of Belgium. For the United States, leavers include teachers appointed to other positions in the education sector.

Source: OECD (2025a), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D8.4.

Regardless of how stable the leaving rate is over time, the teachers who make it up constitute a relevant policy margin. They are already trained, they have much to offer the education system, and they can bring back valuable experience gained in and outside the classroom, which also makes them a credible source for covering the local teacher shortages that most OECD

systems face today (OECD, 2026). The extent to which this margin can be mobilised depends, however, on the reasons that led these teachers to leave, both because those reasons are the levers through which systems can reduce departures and because they condition the design of any policy that seeks to bring former teachers back. The following section reviews what the literature has established on them.

2.2 Determinants of teachers leaving

The reasons why teachers leave the profession have been studied extensively, through surveys and interviews and, more recently, through administrative records of observed departures. Despite this abundance of evidence, ranking the reasons remains difficult. Studies differ in the populations they follow, in the outcomes they measure and in the way motives are grouped. Building on a comprehensive review of this literature and on the two most recent meta-analyses (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024), this paper classifies the reasons into six reasons stated in Table 1. They are presented in this section starting with those that the evidence identifies as most important and ending with the least studied. Each area closes with its implications for policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, and Box 1 at the end of the section summarizes them.

Table 1. Reasons for leaving teaching, by area

Area	Reasons
Professional factors	Loss of professional purpose; limited autonomy over the work; professional standing; exposure to parental complaint and legal risk
Working conditions	Hours and total workload; pupil behaviour and classroom discipline; administrative and documentation demands; limited access to reduced hours; burnout and exhaustion
Organisational factors	School leadership; collegial support and team structure
Accountability and regulation	External inspection and its consequences; certification and licensing requirements
Financial factors	Salary relative to outside options; pension design and its timing incentives; contract insecurity
Personal and life-course factors	Family formation and care; childbirth; health and incapacity; relocation and a partner's circumstances; retirement and career stage

Source: Authors' elaboration on the literature reviewed in this section.

Working conditions

First, working conditions are the most frequently declared reason for intending to leave in international surveys. The area groups working hours and total workload, pupil behaviour and classroom discipline, class size,

administrative demands and the burnout that accumulates when these run together. Workload is understood here as the total time that teaching requires, in the school and in preparation and marking outside it, rather than the hours stipulated by contract. According to TALIS 2024, one in four teachers across the OECD intends to leave the profession within five years, and teachers who report high levels of stress are almost twice as likely to declare that intention. That stress comes mainly from administrative work and marking, from keeping up with changing government requirements and from maintaining classroom discipline (OECD, 2025b).

The surveys that ask leavers about the motives of their decision point particularly to workload, which emerges as the most cited motive among those related to working conditions. Leaver surveys done in the Netherlands, Sweden and Australia are consistent in this respect, although assigning different weights to what workload implies. In the Netherlands, workload, stress and burden were named ahead of every other category by 47% of recent leavers, who described intense working days, little rest within them and recurrent overtime, and 80% of them declared that they could have been retained, most often with less workload or a smaller class (Van Casteren et al., 2023). In Sweden, workload and parental expectations also came first, followed by administrative tasks and the lack of control over one's own work (Statistics Sweden, 2023), while in Australia the intensification of workload ranked second, behind dissatisfaction with school leadership, which is examined later in this section (Brandenburg et al., 2024).

However, teachers do not work longer hours than comparable professionals, when TALIS 2024 responses are compared with those of similarly qualified workers in the Survey of Adult Skills (PIAAC), teachers report fewer weekly hours in 13 of 26 covered countries and no clear difference in another 11 (OECD, 2025b). Hence, the workload that teachers declare goes beyond the number of hours stipulated by contract and mainly reflects the intensity of the work, the preparation and administrative tasks carried out outside school hours, and the burden they perceive in the classroom. A great example is observed in England, where TALIS responses were linked to administrative registers of the school workforce, so actual departures could be observed. Teachers in schools with worse discipline were twice as likely to leave the profession while the number of hours teachers worked did not predict their departure (Sims and Jerrim, 2020).

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first is that the school and the teaching load offered to a returner are part of the policy, since the discipline climate of the school and the load are what drive departures (Sims and Jerrim, 2020; Van Casteren et al., 2023). Hence re-attraction is an opportunity to make a better match between the returning teacher and the school they arrive to. The second follows from the fact that shortages tend to concentrate in disadvantaged and rural schools, where the classroom climate is worst (Simon and Johnson, 2015; UNESCO, 2024): a former teacher sent back to one of these schools on the strength of an incentive alone would meet precisely the conditions that drive departures.

Organisational Factors

Closely linked to the daily pressures of teaching, organisational factors cover the quality of school leadership, the structuring of collaborative time and the degree of support among colleagues. Among these, dissatisfaction with school leadership is one of the most frequently cited predictors of teacher departure (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Simon and Johnson, 2015). Nonetheless, establishing its causal effect is difficult, since teachers and principals self-select into schools and the association partly reflects that sorting rather than the effect of leadership itself.

The studies that overcome this problem, by following the same schools over time or by linking teachers' answers to administrative records of actual departures, confirm that leadership is central. Where teachers perceive their school to be well led, turnover is substantially lower, even after accounting for the other working conditions and for the characteristics of the students, and when the leadership of a school improves, its turnover falls (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Kraft, Marinell and Shen-Wei Yee, 2016). The effect is largest precisely in disadvantaged schools, where an effective principal makes the greatest difference to whether teachers stay (Grissom, 2011).

Additionally, mentorship is another relevant organizational aspect, as it accelerates the pedagogical development of novice educators and mitigates the professional isolation common in early-career years. Across the OECD, however, only 26% of novice teachers had an assigned mentor in 2024, although four in five worked in schools that offer a mentoring programme (OECD, 2025b). Novice teachers who receive induction support are less likely to leave the profession (Nguyen et al., 2020), and precisely for this reason structured induction programmes have become one of the most common retention policies, with encouraging results where they have been evaluated. In England, for instance, the Early Career Framework, which entitles every new teacher to two years of mentoring, has increased retention within the original school (Walker et al., 2024). More broadly, collegial support and collaborative environments are consistently associated with lower intentions to leave (Johnson, Kraft and Papay, 2012; Simon and Johnson, 2015).

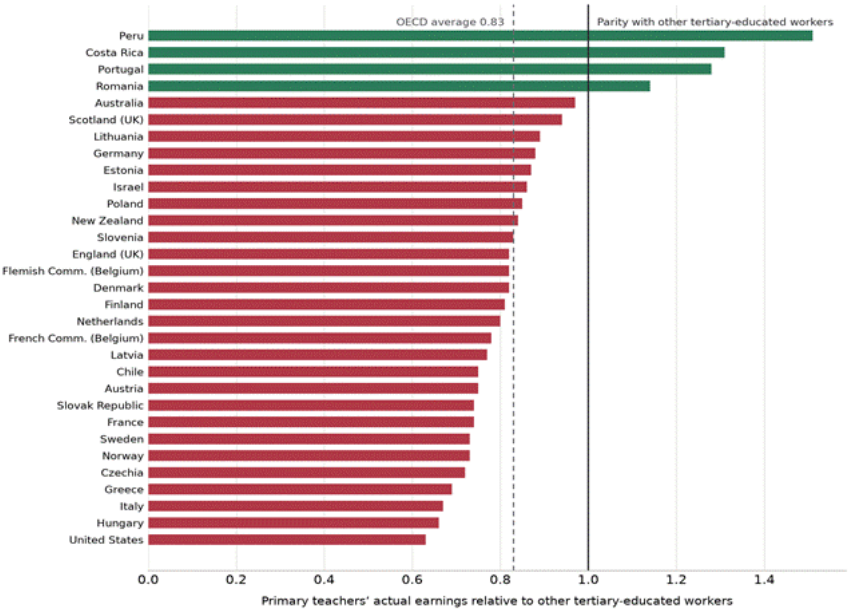
For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, organisational factors matter in two ways. The first concerns the school to which returners are sent, since leadership and collegial support are decisive for all three profiles and a teacher who returns to a school with weak leadership encounters the same conditions that produced the first departure. For this reason, the return process itself could include early contact between the returning teacher and the leadership of the receiving school, so that the match is assessed before the placement is made. The second concerns the contribution that retired teachers can make, since in systems where fewer than one in three novice teachers has a mentor, experienced returners can fill that gap, and the peer interaction they bring has been shown to improve the instruction of their colleagues (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017).

Financial factors

Thirdly, financial factors are the most extensively studied determinant of teacher retention. The area covers the salary relative to outside options, the design of pensions and the insecurity of contracts. From an economic perspective, retention depends on comparing teaching wages with the best alternative available outside. Because outside options vary by subject,

qualification and local labour market, uniform pay scales produce very different exit rates across disciplines and regions. For most teachers the comparison is unfavourable. Actual primary teacher salaries average 83% of the earnings of tertiary-educated workers across the OECD, with large differences across countries (see Figure 2). Only four systems pay at or above parity, led by Portugal at 128% of the benchmark, while the United States registers the lowest ratio at 63% (OECD, 2025d).

Figure 2. Teachers' salary compared to other tertiary-educated workers earnings



Note: Ratio of the average actual salary of full-time primary teachers in public institutions to the earnings of full-time tertiary-educated workers aged 25 to 64. Data refer to 2024 or the nearest available year.

Source: OECD (2025d), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D3.2.

The causal evidence on the effect of teacher payments confirms that financial incentives are effective to retain teachers, and payments cut departures by 9% to 23% in Norway, England and North Carolina (Falch, 2011; Sims and Benhenda, 2022; Clotfelter et al., 2008). This evidence rests on a small number of studies exploiting policy discontinuities, and lead to three main conclusions. Financial incentives are effective when the payment is large and teachers are aware of their eligibility (Falch, 2011; Clotfelter et al., 2008); their effect is confined to the teachers they target and is negligible for the rest (Springer, Swain and Rodriguez, 2016); and one-off bonuses produce larger short-run effects than permanent increases, which indicates that the retention gain does not persist beyond the payment period (Feng and Sass, 2018; See et al., 2020).

Moreover, pension rules also affect the decision to leave, since they set the retirement age and, along the teaching career, create incentives for retention depending on the pension system's rigidity. The retirement age generally falls between 62 and 67, averaging 64.7 for men and 63.9 for women across the OECD. It stands at 62 in Greece and Slovenia, at 67 in Australia, Denmark, Iceland, Israel, the Netherlands and Norway, and in between everywhere else (OECD, 2025f). In most schemes covering teachers, retiring before the age stipulated by law reduces the pension and retiring later marginally increases it, so retirement concentrates around that age (Baraton, Beffy and Fougère, 2011; Ni and Podgursky, 2016). In addition, in many public-service schemes

the pension is not freely compatible with a new salary, and retired teacher who returns sees the pension reduced or suspended once pension and salary together exceed a given threshold, which in practice excludes most retirees from teaching again unless a specific exception is made.

These rules matter because they shape the economic decisions that teachers take around retirement, and this phenomenon is closely related to the way pension entitlements accumulate. In defined-benefit schemes, where the pension is a share of the final salary that depends on years of service rather than on the contributions actually paid, most of the pension is earned in the final years before the full-pension age and little accrues after it, so one more year of work carries a substantial pension gain at 54 and almost nothing at 60 (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009). This is mostly the case across the civil-service teacher schemes of Europe and North America. Defined-contribution systems, where the pension depends on what has been contributed and on the return it has earned, as in Sweden or Australia, are instead close to actuarially neutral and spread retirements accordingly (OECD, 2025e). The available estimates of how much teachers value that deferred income present mixed results, with estimates running from about 20 cents per dollar of present value to near parity (Fitzpatrick, 2015; Ni, Podgursky and Wang, 2022), which suggests that the retention effect of pension rules depends as much on how well teachers understand them as on their actual generosity.

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first concerns retired teachers, for whom pension rules are the main obstacle to returning, the more flexibility a system offers them to teach again without losing their pension, and with the possibility of earning an additional income, the more effective it will be in re-attracting them, which is the logic behind several of the policies examined in Section 3. The second concerns switchers, for whom, as expected, better salaries increase the likelihood of returning. The causal evidence reviewed above nonetheless warns that pay alone retains teachers only while it is paid, so that keeping returners in the profession depends on the working and organisational conditions discussed in the previous areas rather than on the financial incentive that brought them back.

Professional factors

Fourth, professional factors group the motives related to the purpose, autonomy and standing of teaching. This area covers teachers who leave because they no longer find meaning in their work, who feel they have lost control over how to exercise it, or who perceive a deterioration in the standing of the profession, often linked to exposure to parental complaints and legal action.

The available evidence consistently shows that these motives weigh on the decision to leave, both among teachers who intend to leave and among those who have already done so. In Finland a longitudinal survey that followed teachers over five years found that a lack of professional commitment was named persistently, above workload and interpersonal difficulties among teachers declaring an intention to leave the profession (Räsänen et al., 2020). In England teachers who intend to leave give more weight to the feeling that their views are not considered by policymakers than to wages (Department for Education, 2024b). Among actual leavers, the pattern remains consistent. In

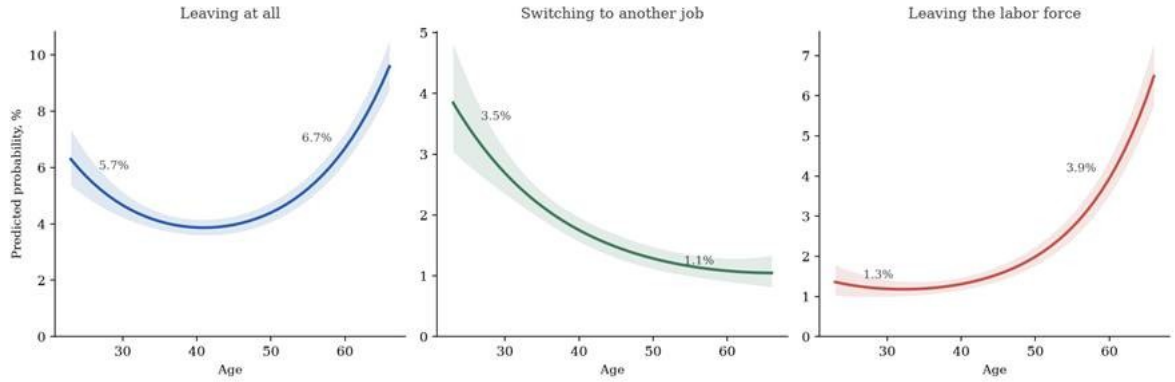
the United States, most switchers rate their new job above teaching in autonomy, influence and professional prestige, although not always in salary (NCES, 2014), and in the leaver surveys of the Netherlands and Sweden the lack of professional challenge and the limited control over one's own work rank among the leading motives, behind working conditions only (Van Casteren et al., 2023; Statistics Sweden, 2023).

Moreover, the apparent decline in the perceived standing of the profession is not only a problem for those who decide to leave. Across the OECD, only 26% of teachers feel that their profession is valued in society, and those who do are over 10% less likely to intend to leave within five years (OECD, 2020; OECD, 2025b). Taken together, the evidence points to recognition and professional purpose as decisive in the leaving decision, consistent with teaching remaining one of the most vocational career choices. This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, and particularly switchers, who are the ones who found elsewhere the autonomy and standing they missed, since it highlights the importance of recognising their previous service, of offering roles that make use of their experience and of initiatives that increase their participation in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors

Fifth, personal and life-course factors drive a substantial share of departures and, unlike the preceding areas, originate entirely outside the school, which makes them the least predictable from an institutional perspective and the least responsive to standard administrative aspects. Along the teaching career, the leaving rate exhibits a pronounced U-shape, concentrated among novice teachers during early-career sorting and among late-career teachers approaching retirement, with a stable middle phase (Nguyen et al., 2020). Figure 3 shows this profile for the United States and separates the two exit routes behind it.

Figure 3. The age profile of leaving teaching in the United States, by exit route



Note: Predicted probabilities of leaving teaching within twelve months, by age, from probit models estimated on Current Population Survey data (March supplements) for college-graduate teachers observed between 2015 and 2024. Each panel comes from a separate model, with age entered as a quadratic, year effects, and the other covariates held at their sample means. Left: leaving teaching by any route; centre: moving to another occupation; right: leaving the labour force. Exits to unemployment are the residual route and are not shown, so the two right panels do not sum exactly to the left one. Shaded bands are 95% confidence intervals. Authors' calculations.

The early peak is driven by switchers, since the probability of moving to another occupation is highest among the youngest teachers and declines steadily with age, as novice teachers leave for further study, family formation or alternative employment while the quality of their match with the profession

is still being revealed (Guarino, Santibañez and Daley, 2006). The late peak is driven by leavers, whose probability of withdrawing from the labour force rises sharply after the age of 55 in response to the retirement incentives just examined (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009).

The teaching workforce is predominantly female, at around seven in ten lower secondary teachers across the OECD (OECD, 2025b). The events of family life weigh on it with particular force, and the birth of a child is the best documented of these motives. In England, where the workforce census follows teachers after maternity leave, between 17% and 20% of those who return leave the profession within a year, doubling the rate of comparable teachers, and women aged 30 to 39 form the largest group among leavers (Department for Education, 2023). Similarly in the United States and Sweden the same event has long driven female exits (Stinebrickner, 2002).

However, childbirth is only the most visible of a broader set of family and health circumstances that lead teachers to withdraw from the labour market, and the leaver surveys that record them show that these circumstances weigh as much as childbirth itself. Personal life reasons, covering health, childcare and the care of relatives, form the most important non-retirement motive among American voluntary leavers, at 15% (NCES, 2024), and the difficulty of combining work and family is named by 15% of Swedish leavers (Statistics Sweden, 2023).

This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, since those who left over a birth or a family obligation did not leave over the conditions of the school, and the constraint behind the exit tends to ease with time. The evidence nonetheless suggests that their return does not follows on its own when the family circumstances that generated the leaving decision have ceased, only a minority of those who leave come back (Grissom and Reininger, 2012; Moyer, 2022). Flexibility therefore emerges as the central lever for this profile. Part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care responsibilities improve re-entry in general and, above all, facilitate the return of those who leave temporarily.

Accountability and regulation

Finally, accountability and regulation group the motives related to external teacher evaluation and to statutory licensing rules. In general, the evaluation of teachers can be divided into internal evaluations, carried out by the school's own leadership, and external evaluation, carried out by a public body, usually a national or regional inspection regulated by education ministries or equivalent authorities. The internal revisions are common, since 64% of teachers across the OECD work in schools where the principal evaluates every teacher at least once a year and 51% in schools where other members of the management team do so, most often on the basis of classroom observation (OECD, 2020).

Beyond evaluation, maintaining a valid teaching license requires meeting specific regulatory obligations that vary by country, typically taking the form of mandatory periodic training or documented evidence of continued classroom practice. The obligation consists either of completing training, which ranges from 8 hours a year in Luxembourg to 35 in Scotland and from three to five days in Belgium, Finland, Cyprus, Lithuania and Slovenia (European Commission/EACEA/Eurydice, 2021), or of a minimum amount of

teaching, such as 20 days a year in Australia or two years of classroom practice in New Zealand (Victorian Institute of Teaching, 2025; Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2016).

However, what matters for leavers is the additional time and work these obligations imply, since nearly half report that evaluation in their school is carried out merely to fulfil administrative requirements, without producing feedback they can use, and 54% that their mandatory training competes with their working schedule (OECD, 2020). The importance of accountability and regulation motives is nonetheless minor compared to other determinants of leaving, since even if test-based accountability does elevate stress and turnover intentions (Ryan et al., 2017), it ranks below affective commitment, burnout and job satisfaction (Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024).

For policies aiming to re-attract former teachers, this suggests that the cost of re-certification deserves particular attention. Licensing requirements rarely drive fully qualified teachers out of the profession, although teachers who entered without full certification do leave at higher rates (Redding and Smith, 2016), but they become a real barrier at the moment of return, since a lapsed licence must be renewed and the cost and the isolation that teachers face in navigating the process deter re-entry and reduce retention once back. This concerns all three profiles and argues for keeping such burdens as low as regulatory purposes allow.

General overview

Not all these motives have been studied with the same intensity, and their relative importance cannot be compared perfectly across studies. The best basis for doing so comes from the two meta-analyses used throughout this section, which together pool several hundred studies of teacher turnover and estimate the weight of each antecedent for intentions as well as for observed departures (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024). Both point to working conditions and the organisational features of the school as the most consistent determinants of leaving, above financial incentives, accountability and personal characteristics. Teachers exposed to high workload, stress and weak organisational support are substantially more likely to leave, while pay and regulation, although relevant, have smaller effects. This does not make personal motives secondary for every teacher. It means that the conditions under which teaching takes place are the main institutional margin through which systems can influence retention.

This distinction matters for policies that aim to re-attract former teachers. Bringing a teacher back without changing the conditions under which they left risks reproducing the same decision later on. Re-entry policies should therefore be understood not only as a way to reduce the cost of returning, but as an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, a manageable load, supportive leadership and colleagues, adequate classroom conditions and, where the exit was personal, the flexibility to combine teaching with family responsibilities. The relevant question is not simply how to make former teachers return, but whether the system can offer them a different set of conditions once they do.

Box 1. What the reasons for leaving teach us about re-attracting former teachers

Each reason for leaving points to a profile of former teachers and to a lever for bringing them back.

Working conditions. *Switchers and leavers.* What drives departures is the climate of the classroom more than the hours worked. Because shortages concentrate in the schools where that climate is worst, a returner placed there on the strength of an incentive alone is likely to leave again. The school a returner is placed in and the teaching load they are offered are part of the policy.

Organisational factors. *All profiles.* Supportive leadership and collegial support are the most consistent predictors of staying, so returners should go to schools where they exist. Retired teachers can also supply what is missing: only one in four novice teachers has a mentor, and mentoring is the organisational lever with the clearest effect on early-career retention.

Financial factors. *Switchers and retired teachers.* Pay brings teachers back and keeps them only for as long as it is paid. For retired teachers the binding constraint is not the salary but the pension rules that penalise working after retirement; removing those penalties costs little and acts directly on the largest reserve of experienced teachers.

Professional factors. *Mainly switchers.* Those who leave for another job rate it above teaching in autonomy, influence and standing, more than in pay. Bringing them back means recognising their previous service, offering roles that use their experience and giving them a say in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors. *Mainly leavers.* Those who left over a birth, care or health did not leave over the school, and the constraint often eases with time. Yet they no longer return on their own: only about one in five does. They respond to flexibility, through part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care, and to being asked.

Accountability and regulation. *Minor as a reason for leaving, decisive for re-entry.* Licensing and training obligations rarely drive qualified teachers out, but a lapsed licence must be renewed, and the cost and complexity of doing so deter those considering a return. Re-certification should be as light as its purpose allows.

Overall. Working conditions and the organisation of the school outweigh pay, regulation and personal characteristics as reasons for leaving. The conditions a former teacher returns to therefore matter as much as the incentive that brings them back, and a policy driven only by shortages, which places returners in the hardest schools, risks reproducing the first departure. Seen in this light, re-entry policies are also an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, through the workload, the leadership, the collegial environment, the classroom conditions and the flexibility that returners are offered.

3. The policies

Teacher shortages, ageing workforces and the large number of qualified teachers who leave the profession before retirement have led many education systems to look at former teachers as a source of teacher supply. The measures adopted to bring them back are highly heterogeneous, and they range from changes to the pension rules that keep retired teachers out of the classroom to personal letters, refresher courses and new roles as tutors or mentors. This section provides an international perspective on these measures, drawing on 30 policies adopted in 18 countries and economies between 1996 and 2026. They were identified through a desk-based review of legal texts, official documents, parliamentary records and evaluations, complemented with reputable press reports where no official source exists and with information provided by officials in Lower Saxony (Germany), Quebec (Canada) and New Zealand.

The section first proposes a framework that classifies the policies according to the main instrument they use, and applies it to the 30 policies identified. It then describes the objectives, duration and available evidence of these policies, before examining each instrument in turn. Each instrument is illustrated with one or more boxes showcasing a policy from a specific system, and Box 13, at the end of the section, brings together what each instrument suggests for the design of re-entry policies, following the structure of Box 1.

3.1 A framework for policies to re-attract former teachers

In developing a framework for policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, a first step involves identifying the criteria by which these policies can be meaningfully distinguished. The policies reviewed differ along many dimensions, such as the profile of former teachers they target, the level of government that runs them, their duration or the resources they mobilise. The framework proposed here classifies them according to the main instrument they use, since the instrument reflects the barrier to re-entry that each policy seeks to lower. Five instruments were identified, each of which can take

several forms. Table 2 presents their definitions and the categories into which the policies under each instrument can be grouped.

Table 2. Instruments and categories of policies to re-attract former teachers

Instrument	Definition	Categories	Category description
Financial incentives	Change the economic return to teaching for former teachers who come back.	*Rules on combining pension and salary*	Waivers, higher or abolished earnings ceilings, shorter waiting periods or full returns in shortage posts that allow retirees to teach while keeping their pension.
		Direct payments to returners	Salary steps, premiums, allowances or fees paid to the teachers who return.
		Payments to schools	Grants to the schools or employers that hire returners.
Information and nudges	Make former teachers aware of the options to return or prompt them to consider it.	*Outreach to retired teachers*	Letters and contact through principals addressed to teachers about to retire or already retired.
		Outreach to recent leavers	Calls or campaigns addressed to teachers who left in recent years, often with help to return.
		Advisory services and information sessions	Advisers or sessions that explain how to return and which posts are available.
Support and training	Reduce the practical cost of returning by updating skills and building confidence.	*Refresher programmes*	Courses, online or school-based, on the changes in curricula, assessment and practice.
		Supervised placements and induction	Paid time in a school, mentoring or induction during the first months back.
Flexible positions	Offer roles other than a full-time teaching post.	*Pools of relief and adjunct teachers*	Registers of former teachers whom schools can hire for short or part-time appointments.
		Placements in hard-to-staff schools	Fixed-term placements of returners in schools with staffing difficulties.
		Mentoring and tutoring	Roles supporting new teachers, student teachers or pupils who are falling behind.
Flexible re-certification	Lower the regulatory requirements to teach again.	*Re-certification linked to a job offer*	Renewal of the licence through a plan agreed with the employing school instead of an external course.
		Simplified licensing and checks	Reissue of lapsed licences, waived documents or faster checks of records and accreditation.

Note: Categories derived from the 30 policies reviewed in this section, listed in Table 3.

The other dimensions considered during the development of the framework, namely the target group, the level of government and the period of application, are not used as classification criteria, but they are reported for each policy in Table 3. Importantly, the framework is designed as a practical typology intended to provide guidance rather than a prescriptive standard. Many policies combine several instruments, and the boundaries between categories are often blurred. Each policy is therefore assigned to the instrument that defines it best, while its secondary instruments are also indicated in Table 3.

Building on these instruments, the framework was applied systematically to the 30 policies identified through the desk-based review. Financial incentives are the main instrument of 12 of them, and in most cases they take the form of changes to the rules on combining a pension with a salary, such as the Irish waiver or the decision of Lower Saxony (Germany) to abolish the earnings ceiling for retired teachers who have reached the statutory retirement age.

Seven policies offer flexible positions, from the adjunct teachers whom schools in Singapore can hire for short periods to the retired teachers who serve for at least a school year in Chinese rural schools.

Five policies rely on information and nudges, such as the personal letter that the Minister of Education of Lower Saxony sent to every teacher about to retire to explain how to continue teaching, or the calls that the education department of New South Wales (Australia) made to teachers who had left its schools in the previous five years. Four policies provide support and training, such as the paid school placements offered to former teachers in Victoria (Australia), and the remaining two make re-certification more flexible, as New Zealand has done for returners who already have a job offer (Section 3.6).

The policies target the three profiles of former teachers unevenly (Table 3). Of the 30 policies, 19 are addressed to retired teachers only, 7 to switchers and leavers, and 4 are open to all former teachers. Several features of retired teachers account for this prominence. They are easy to identify through pension records, they are fully qualified and many retire before they wish to stop working altogether. Moreover, as discussed in Section 2, the main obstacle to their return lies in a rule that governments control directly, the reduction or suspension of the pension when a retiree takes paid work in the public sector. Changing that rule requires no new programme and has a limited cost, which explains why it is the most frequent policy in the review. Switchers and leavers, who represent the majority of former teachers below retirement age, are the target of fewer and smaller programmes, most of them focused on support and training.

Table 3. Policies to re-attract former teachers, by main instrument

Country or economy, policy and period, target group, instruments used and scale of implementation

Country or economy	Policy and period	Target	Instruments					Scale
			Fin.	Inf.	Sup.	Pos.	Rec.	
Financial incentives								
Canada, Ontario	Higher limit on the days that retired teachers can work without losing their pension, 95 instead of 50 (2020/21-2022/23)	R	●			○		Subnational
Canada, Quebec	Pay on the salary scale and premiums for retired supply teachers (2020-)	R	●	○		○		Subnational
France	Combination of pension and salary for retired teachers (standing rule)	R	●			○		National
Germany, Lower Saxony	Higher earnings ceiling for retired teachers (2022), abolished past the statutory age (2024)	R	●	○				Subnational
Ireland	Waiver of pension reduction for the first 50 days worked each year (2021-2027)	R	●			○		National
Netherlands	Grant to primary schools that re-hire former teachers (2017-2020)	S/L	●		○			National
Portugal	Fixed-term contracts for recently retired teachers in shortage posts (2024-2026)	R	●			○		National
United States, Georgia	Full-time return with full pension in high-need subjects (2022-2026)	R	●					Subnational
United States, Louisiana	Return to critical-shortage posts without pension reduction (2024-)	R	●			○		Subnational
United States, Michigan	Shorter waiting period and no earnings limit for returning retirees (2023-2028)	R	●					Subnational

Country or economy	Policy and period	Target	Instruments					Scale
			Fin.	Inf.	Sup.	Pos.	Rec.	
United States, New Mexico	Return to work without earnings limit for retired educators (2022-)	R	●					Subnational
United States, North Carolina	Full-time return with salary and pension (1999-2009)	R	●					Subnational
Information and nudges								
Australia, New South Wales	Calls to teachers who left in the previous five years, with help to return (2023-)	All		●	○	○		Subnational
Austria	Letters and contact through principals to keep or re-hire retired teachers (2022-)	R	○	●				Subnational
Germany, Lower Saxony	Minister's letter to teachers about to retire and simplified re-employment (2023-)	R	○	●			○	Subnational
Japan, Miyazaki Prefecture	Information session for licence holders who are not teaching (2025)	S/L		●	○	○		Subnational
United Kingdom, England	Advisory service for returning teachers (standing service)	S/L		●	○			National
Support and training								
Australia, Victoria	Paid placement of up to 40 days in a school before applying (2022-)	All	○	○	●			Subnational
Sweden	Online refresher course for returning teachers (launched in 2018)	S/L			●			National
Switzerland, canton of Zurich	Re-entry assessment and induction for returning teachers (standing offer)	S/L		○	●			Subnational
United Kingdom, England	Return to Teaching pilot (2016) and Returners Engagement Programme (2016-2018)	S/L	○	○	●			National
Flexible positions								
Bahamas	Reserve of former teachers, retirees and graduates (2026-)	All				●	○	National
China	Silver-Age Lecturing Plan, retired teachers in rural schools (2018-)	R	○			●		National
Singapore	Pool of adjunct teachers hired directly by schools (2004-)	All				●		National
Spain, Zaragoza	Retired teachers mentor student teachers (2018)	R		○		●		Local
United States	AARP Foundation Experience Corps, volunteers tutor young readers (1996-)	R			○	●		National
United States, Colorado	Retired teachers mentor new teachers in Aurora (2013/14-2014/15)	R				●		Local
United States, four urban districts	Retired and substitute teachers tutor first graders in mathematics (trial, 2015)	R			○	●		Local
Flexible re-certification								
New Zealand	Return-to-practice plan in place of a refresher course, and payment of registration fees (2024-)	S/L	○				●	National
United States, Virginia	Licences for retirees with lapsed licences (2022) and return to critical-shortage posts (2001-2028)	R	○				●	Subnational

Note: ● main instrument; ○ secondary instrument. Fin. financial incentives; Inf. information and nudges; Sup. support and training; Pos. flexible positions; Rec. flexible re-certification. Target R refers to retired teachers, S/L to switchers and leavers and All to the three profiles. Scale refers to the level of government or institution that runs the policy. AARP Foundation Experience Corps recruits adults aged 50 and over, among them former teachers.

Source: Legal texts, official documents, parliamentary records and evaluations cited in Section 3, verified in October 2026.

We acknowledge the considerable diversity of the education systems reviewed, which operate at national, regional and local levels. For the sake of simplicity, the name of the country is used even when a policy applies only at a subnational level, and where this is the case it is indicated in the tables and boxes. Furthermore, the policies showcased in the boxes are not intended to reflect the most prevalent approach in each country. They were selected to illustrate the instruments described in the framework and to cover a variety of education systems and continents, and they should not be read as representative of the national system in which they operate.

Objectives of the policies

Most of the policies reviewed were introduced to respond to teacher shortages, and in particular to shortages concentrated in specific subjects, regions or types of school. Georgia (United States), for example, allowed teachers who had retired after a full career to return full-time without losing their pension, but only to teach the subjects of highest need in their region, while Portugal allowed schools to hire recently retired teachers for shortage posts (Section 3.2). China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan serves the same purpose by sending retired principals and senior teachers to rural schools where vacancies are hardest to fill (Section 3.5).

The COVID-19 pandemic gave a strong impulse to these policies, because the absence of serving teachers multiplied the need for substitutes at a time when few were available. In autumn 2020, Quebec (Canada) began to pay retired supply teachers according to their experience instead of a flat daily rate, and Ontario (Canada) temporarily allowed retired teachers to work more days a year without losing their pension. In 2021 Ireland waived, for a limited number of working days each year, the reduction that public-service pensions normally suffer when a retiree returns to paid work, and in December of that year the Department for Education in England called on recently retired teachers and career changers to cover the absences caused by the Omicron wave, even if only for one day a week (Department for Education, 2021).

A smaller group of policies pursues a different objective, which is to make use of the experience of former teachers in roles that serving teachers rarely have the time to perform. In Aurora, Colorado (United States), recently retired teachers were paid to mentor new teachers in high-poverty elementary schools, and in several US school districts retired teachers have tutored young pupils who were falling behind in mathematics or reading. The University of Zaragoza (Spain) invited retired teachers to mentor student teachers, and the Chinese programme mentioned above also asks retired teachers to coach the young teachers of the schools that receive them. Singapore's adjunct teaching programme has a related aim, which is to keep teachers who resign in contact with schools by allowing them to work on short and flexible appointments.

Duration and take-up

Most of the policies reviewed are short-term remedies, designed to fill vacancies quickly in the places where shortages are most acute, and several were enacted with an end date and later renewed one period at a time. The Irish waiver, introduced in 2021, has been extended twice and now runs until the end of 2027, and Quebec has never made its incentives permanent and renegotiates them every school year with the teacher unions. Other policies were reversed after a short period. Ontario returned in 2024 to its usual limit

on the days that retired teachers can work, and in September 2026 Portugal repealed its programme for hiring retired teachers, two years after creating it, on the grounds that it was no longer justified (Government of Portugal, 2026).

Where take-up is reported, it is small relative to the size of the teaching workforce. In Germany, a survey of the federal states found that more than 5 000 retired teachers had stayed on in schools or returned to them by 2023, under 1% of the almost 800 000 teachers in the country (Kuhn, 2023). The same order of magnitude is found in Georgia (Box 2), and in Portugal only 55 retired teachers were validated for the 200 places offered in the first round of the programme (Observador, 2024).

These figures should nonetheless be read in the light of the large number of teachers who return without the help of any specific programme. In England, returners accounted for 17 740 full-time equivalent qualified teachers entering state schools in 2025/26, which represents 43.3% of all qualified entrants, up from 39.6% in 2023/24, and exceeds the 16 300 newly qualified teachers who started that year (Department for Education, 2026a). In Sweden, about 3% of the teaching workforce returned to the profession in 2019 (Skolverket, 2020). The number of former teachers who return thus appears to depend at least as much on the conditions of the profession as on any of the instruments reviewed in this section.

Available evidence

Evidence on the effectiveness of these policies is scarce. Only 10 of the 30 policies have been the subject of some form of evaluation, which ranges from audits and descriptive studies of administrative data to three randomised controlled trials (Table 4). The three trials concern retired teachers working as mentors of new teachers and as tutors of young pupils in mathematics and reading, and they provide the strongest evidence in this review. Official reviews of a refresher pilot in England, a hiring grant for schools in the Netherlands and an online course for returners in Sweden, presented in Sections 3.2 and 3.4, reached less encouraging conclusions. The studies of the rules on combining a pension with a salary in several US states describe how many retirees returned and where they went, but cannot identify the effect of these rules on vacancies or on pupils' learning.

The retention of returners once they are back in school is almost never measured, and Georgia is a rare exception (Box 2). In most systems the available data do not allow returners to be linked to the policy that brought them back, and some systems lack the unique teacher identifier that would be needed to follow individual careers over time.

Table 4. Evaluations of policies to re-attract former teachers

Type of evidence, data and main results, by instrument

Country or economy	Policy	Type of evidence	Data or sample	Main results
Financial incentives				
United States, Georgia	Full-time return in high-need subjects	State audit	Administrative data, 2023-2025	About 350 returners a year, under 1% of teachers; 64% returned to their former system; 43% of the 2023 cohort still teaching two years later

Country or economy	Policy	Type of evidence	Data or sample	Main results
United States, North Carolina	Full-time return with salary and pension	Descriptive study	Administrative data, 1999-2009	About 3 500 returners; 54% returned to their own school; returners more often employed in the poorest schools; effects on vacancies not identified
United States, Virginia	Return to critical-shortage posts	Retirement system report	Administrative data, 2008-2023	Shorter break in service raised returns between July and October from 18 to 150
Netherlands	Grant to schools that re-hire former teachers	Ministry evaluation	Reports of school boards, 2017-2020	274 returners funded; most would have been hired anyway; grant not extended
Austria	Re-employment of retired teachers	Qualitative study	14 interviews with returners	None of the returners interviewed would repeat their return
Support and training				
United Kingdom, England	Return to Teaching pilot	Independent evaluation with comparison group	5 729 registrants, 354 supported	27 in permanent posts in targeted subjects; GBP 37 400 per additional returner
Sweden	Online refresher course	Agency report with participant survey	1 018 registered participants	38 completed the course; did not reach its target group
Flexible positions				
United States, Colorado	Retired teachers mentor new teachers	Randomised controlled trial	77 teachers, 11 schools	Mathematics +0.064 after one year, not significant after two; no effect on reading or retention
United States, four urban districts	Small-group tutoring in mathematics	Randomised controlled trial	994 pupils, 76 schools	Mathematics +0.34
United States	AARP Foundation Experience Corps	Randomised controlled trial	881 pupils, 23 schools	Reading comprehension +0.13 to +0.17 for pupils with 35 sessions or more

Note: Effect sizes are standardised mean differences in pupils' test scores between the treatment and control groups.

Source: Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts (2025), *Retired Teachers Return to Work*; Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler (2024); Virginia Retirement System (2023), *Report on Retirees Returning to Work in Critical Shortage Positions*; Tweede Kamer (2020), Kamerstuk 35300-VIII, nr. 212; Resch (2025); Buchanan et al. (2018), *Evaluation of the Return to Teaching Pilot Programme*; Skolverket (2020); DeCesare et al. (2017); Gersten et al. (2015); Morrow-Howell et al. (2009).

3.2 Financial incentives

This type of policy is designed to make the return to teaching worthwhile in economic terms, and it is addressed almost exclusively to retired teachers. Its core rationale is that, for retired teachers, the decision to return to the classroom depends less on the salary on offer than on what happens to their pension once they accept it (Box 1). The approach is present in most of the systems reviewed, such as France, Georgia (depicted in Box 2), Ireland, Lower Saxony, Ontario and Quebec (depicted in Box 3), and it tends to respond to shortages of substitutes or of teachers in specific subjects. The policies take two forms. The most common modifies the rules that govern the combination of a pension with a salary, so that retired teachers can work again without losing all or part of their pension, while a smaller group offers direct payments, either to the teachers who return or to the schools that hire them.

Rules on combining a pension with a salary

In most public-service pension plans, a retired teacher who takes up paid work in the public sector sees the pension reduced or suspended once the pension and the new salary together exceed a given threshold, or once the number of

days worked exceeds a given limit. Table 5 compares how the policies reviewed relax these rules. Ireland and Ontario allow retirees to work a fixed number of days each year without any reduction of the pension. In Ireland, a public-service pension is reduced when the new earnings and the pension together exceed the salary that the retiree received at the time of retirement, uprated over time. Since 2021 the Department of Education has waived this reduction for the first 50 days that a retired teacher works in each calendar year, with any day worked counting as a full day regardless of the hours taught. The waiver applies only where the need for a teacher cannot practicably be met in another way and excludes retirees who take a post that extends beyond 50 days, since its purpose is to provide substitutes for short absences (Department of Education, 2026).

Ontario applies a similar logic to the school year. Retired teachers can work up to 50 days in each school year and keep their full pension, which is otherwise suspended from the end of the month in which the limit is exceeded. Between 2020/21 and 2022/23, the provincial government and the Ontario Teachers' Federation, which jointly sponsor the teachers' pension plan, raised this limit to 95 days in each school year, only for positions that could not be filled by other qualified teachers and with monthly reports from school boards on how retirees were used (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2020).

Other systems have raised or removed the earnings ceiling for all retired teachers, and they differ mainly in how long retirees must wait before returning and in whether any limit on earnings remains. In October 2022 the parliament of Lower Saxony raised the ceiling on the combined pension and salary of retired civil-service teachers from 125% to 150% of their pensionable pay, and in October 2024 it abolished the ceiling for those who have reached the statutory retirement age, as part of the broader approach described in Box 4. In France, a retired teacher who has claimed all pensions and receives a full-rate pension can combine it with a salary without any limit, and since 2023 the new work also generates additional pension rights, while for other retirees the pension is reduced once earnings exceed a threshold (Assemblée nationale, 2026). In 2023 Michigan (United States) shortened the waiting period after retirement from nine to six months, after which retirees can take any school post without an earnings limit (Michigan Office of Retirement Services, 2023), and New Mexico has allowed retired educators since 2022 to return 90 days after retiring with no limit on earnings. In New Mexico each return must be approved by the state's Educational Retirement Board, and the maximum period of return was extended from 36 to 60 months in 2025 (New Mexico Educational Retirement Board, 2025).

Several US states have instead tied a full return, with a full salary and a full pension, to posts that are hard to fill, and the restrictions they impose largely determine how many retirees come back. Georgia tied the return to the subjects of highest need in each region (Box 2). Louisiana's Act 344 of 2026 requires retirees to wait 12 months before returning and limits their earnings to 50% of their final average pay, up from 25%, except in posts certified as critical shortages, where they can earn a full salary without any reduction of the pension. To certify a shortage, the employer must have advertised the post and received fewer than three applications from qualified candidates who are not retired (Teachers' Retirement System of Louisiana, 2026). Virginia has allowed retirees to return to critical-shortage posts while keeping their

pension since 2001, and retirees filled 699 such posts between 2008 and 2022. In July 2023 the state shortened the break in service required before a return from 12 to 6 months, extended the rule to specialist support posts and prolonged it until July 2028, after which the number of retirees returning between July and October rose from 18 in 2022 to 150 in 2023 (Virginia Retirement System, 2023).

Between 1999 and 2009, retired teachers in North Carolina could return to a full-time post and draw their salary and pension together, which raised their income by as much as half. The rule initially applied only to low-performing schools and was extended to all schools in 2000. About 3 500 teachers returned under it, more than half of them (54%) to their own school, and returners were more frequently employed in the poorest schools, where 30% of them worked, against 21% in the least poor quartile of schools (Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler, 2024). Portugal, by contrast, opted for a highly restrictive design. Its Decree-Law 51/2024 limited fixed-term contracts to teachers who had retired in the previous five years, to posts in shortage subjects or in under-staffed schools and to an annual national quota. Returners kept their pension and received an additional payment linked to the first step of the salary scale, in proportion to their weekly hours (Government of Portugal, 2024), but most of the places offered went unfilled before the programme was repealed.

The rules also differ in how they treat pension contributions, which determines both their cost for the pension system and the incentive they create to retire early. In Georgia, New Mexico, Louisiana and, since 2023, Virginia, contributions are paid on the salary of returners without increasing their pension, and in Georgia the employer even paid the employee’s share. Designs of this kind make the return possible while preventing retirees from accumulating additional pension entitlements at the expense of the system.

Table 5. Rules on combining a pension with a salary for retired teachers in selected systems

Eligibility, limits on work or earnings, posts covered and treatment of pension contributions

System	Eligibility	Limit on work or earnings	Posts covered	Pension contributions	Period
Limits on days worked					
Canada, Ontario	Retired members of the teachers’ pension plan	50 days a school year, 95 in 2020/21-2022/23; pension suspended beyond the limit	Any post; higher limit only where no other qualified teacher was available	..	Standing rule
Ireland	Qualified retired teachers	Pension reduction waived for the first 50 days worked in a calendar year	Substitute and fixed-term work where the need cannot be met otherwise	..	2021-2027
Higher or no earnings ceiling					
France	Retired teachers	No limit with a full-rate pension and all pensions claimed; earnings threshold otherwise	Any post	New pension rights since 2023 for full-rate retirees	Standing rule
Germany, Lower Saxony	Retired civil-service teachers	Pension and salary up to 150% of pensionable pay from 2022 (125% before); no limit past the statutory age from 2024	Any post	..	2022-

System	Eligibility	Limit on work or earnings	Posts covered	Pension contributions	Period
United States, Michigan	Retirees, after six months (nine before 2023)	No limit after six months; USD 15 100 a year during the waiting period	Any post	..	2023-2028
United States, New Mexico	Retirees, 90 days after retiring, with approval of the retirement board	No earnings limit, for up to 60 months (36 before 2025)	Any public school or higher education post	Paid by employer and employee, without new pension rights	2022-
Full return in hard-to-fill posts					
United States, Georgia	30 years of service and one year in retirement	Full salary and full pension	Full-time posts in the subjects of highest need in the region	Employer pays both contributions, without new pension rights	2022-2026
United States, Louisiana	Retirees, after 12 months	Earnings up to 50% of final average pay (25% before 2026); no limit in critical-shortage posts	Critical-shortage posts advertised without three qualified applicants who are not retired	Paid by employer and employee	2026-
United States, North Carolina	Retired teachers	Full salary and full pension	Low-performing schools in 1999, all schools from 2000	..	1999-2009
United States, Virginia	Retirees, after six months (12 before 2023)	Full salary and full pension	Critical-shortage posts, and specialist support posts since 2023	Employer contributions since 2023, without new pension rights	2001-2028
Portugal	Teachers retired five years or less	Pension and an additional payment linked to the first step of the salary scale	Shortage subjects and under-staffed schools, within an annual quota	..	2024-2026

Note: .. information not available. Rules as in force in October 2026 or, for policies that have ended, during their last year of application.

Source: Department of Education (2026), Circular 0017/2026; Ontario Teachers' Federation (2020); Assemblée nationale (2026); Niedersächsischer Landtag (2024), Drucksache 19/5338; Michigan Office of Retirement Services (2023); New Mexico Educational Retirement Board (2025); Teachers Retirement System of Georgia (2026); Teachers' Retirement System of Louisiana (2026); Virginia Retirement System (2023); Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler (2024); Government of Portugal (2024), Decreto-Lei n.º 51/2024.

Box 2. Full return in high-need subjects in Georgia (United States)

Purpose and origins. House Bill 385, in force between July 2022 and June 2026, was designed to bring experienced retired teachers back into the subjects where Georgia's school systems found it hardest to recruit. It allowed them to return to a full-time classroom post and receive a full salary on top of their full pension.

Design and delivery. Eligible teachers had retired with at least 30 years of service and had been retired for at least a year. The post had to be in one of the subjects of highest need in their region, as determined by the regional education service agency, and the employer paid both the employer and the employee contributions to the pension fund, while the returner earned no further service credit.

Participants and take-up. A state audit published in 2025 found that 635 retirees returned under the law between 2023 and 2025, a number that rose from 241 to 428 a year and averaged about 350, under 1% of the state's teachers. Just over half of school systems (55%) used the law, 64% of returners went back to the system they had retired from, and in 56% of the systems that used the law the post had first been offered to a candidate who was not retired (Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, 2025).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. Of the retirees hired in 2023, 43% were still teaching two years later, one of the few retention figures available for returners. Strict eligibility kept the cost of the rule low but also limited its reach, and 45 of the 72 school systems that did not use the law reported that they would have done so had they found an eligible retiree (Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, 2025). Senate Bill 150, which replaced the law until June 2030, requires at least half of the returner's timetable to be in a qualifying subject, such as mathematics, science, special education or career and technical education, and lets each school system define its own areas of highest need on the basis of a five-year average of vacancies (Teachers Retirement System of Georgia, 2026).

Source: Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts (2025), *Retired Teachers Return to Work*; Teachers Retirement System of Georgia (2026), "SB 150 FAQs".

Direct payments to returners and schools

Direct payments are less common among the policies reviewed, and most of them are made to the returners themselves. Since 2020 Quebec has paid retired teachers who cover absences at the step of the salary scale that corresponds to their experience from the first day of work, together with a premium that has been renegotiated every year (Box 3). Payments to returners also appear as a secondary instrument in several of the policies presented in later sections, as an honorarium during a school placement, an allowance for teachers posted to remote schools or the payment of registration fees.

The Netherlands chose instead to pay the schools that hired returners. Between 2017 and 2020, primary school boards could claim EUR 2 500 for each qualified teacher they hired after a break of at least a year, to cover the cost of coaching and refresher training during the first months back (Ministerie van OCW, 2017). The grant was used for 274 returners, well below the number that the budget allowed, and school boards reported to the ministry that most of these teachers would have been hired and supported without it. The ministry concluded that the grant had contributed only to a

limited extent and did not extend it (Tweede Kamer, 2020). The pool of potential returners in the country remains large, with 34 000 qualified primary teachers and 64 000 secondary and vocational teachers not working in education in 2024 (DUO, 2026), but most of them already work in other parts of the public sector, such as health care (de Vries, van Klaveren and Stolp, 2025). The Dutch experience illustrates a general risk of payments to employers, which may reward hiring decisions that would have been taken in any case.

Box 3. Experience-based pay for retired supply teachers in Quebec (Canada)

Purpose and origins. Until 2020, a retired teacher who covered an absence in a Quebec public school was paid the flat daily rate for supply teaching and reached the salary scale only after 20 consecutive days in the same replacement. In September 2020, during the COVID-19 health emergency, a government decree modified the collective agreements so that teachers who had retired in the previous five years would be paid from the first day at the step of the scale that matched their experience and qualifications, while keeping their full pension and without paying further contributions (Conseil exécutif du Québec, 2020).

Design and delivery. For a retiree at the top of the scale, daily pay rose from a usual maximum of about CAD 212 to about CAD 412 (Gouvernement du Québec, 2022). A premium of 7.89% was added from 1 October 2021, and when the emergency measures ended with the 2021/22 school year the government chose to continue the incentives through letters of agreement signed every year with each teacher union federation outside the collective agreements. The premium stood at 7.89% until 2023/24, was split in 2024/25 into 7.5% on supply work and 12.5% on contracts of three months or more, and has been limited since 2025/26 to 12.5% on contracts of one month or more. The Ministry of Education funds the measure after the fact, on the basis of the use of retired staff that school service centres report at the end of each year.

Participants and take-up. The original five-year limit was lifted, and the agreement now covers any retired teacher who is legally qualified to teach, although employers must first offer the work to the qualified staff they already employ. About 700 retirees returned in 2020/21, more than 2 900 in 2022/23 and more than 5 000 in 2024/25 (Desrosiers, 2023; Le Devoir, 2025).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. Because the payment is made only for the days actually worked, the government estimated the cost at about CAD 4 545 per retiree for each 20-day replacement (Conseil exécutif du Québec, 2020). The envelope for 2026/27 is being adjusted downwards as fewer retirees are used and the 7.5% premium has been withdrawn (Ministère de l'Éducation du Québec, 2026), and the annual renegotiation leaves retirees and school service centres uncertain about the conditions that will apply from one year to the next.

Source: Conseil exécutif du Québec (2020), "Mémoire au Conseil des ministres"; Gouvernement du Québec (2022), "Opération main-d'œuvre"; Desrosiers (2023), "La prime de 12 000 $ boudée par des enseignants retraités"; Le Devoir (2025); Ministère de l'Éducation du Québec (2026), presentation to the OECD.

Implications for re-entry policies

The experience with financial incentives carries two implications. The first is that the conditions attached to a rule matter as much as the incentive itself. Returns to Virginia's schools in the first months of the school year rose

eightfold once the required break in service was shortened, whereas the narrow eligibility rules of Georgia and Portugal left many schools without any retiree who could fill their vacancies. Rules that allow a full return also tend to bring retirees back to the subjects and schools where they are most needed, as the cases of Georgia and North Carolina show, although most returners go back to the school or system where they used to work. These rules therefore seem to help schools keep their own experienced teachers for longer rather than attract retirees to new schools.

The second is that these rules raise concerns that governments need to weigh. When the Ontario Teachers' Federation, which co-sponsors the teachers' pension plan, refused to extend the higher limit on working days in 2024, it argued that more than 30 000 certified teachers were not employed by school boards and that a generous rule could encourage early retirement (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2024). Payments to schools, as the Dutch grant showed, carry a different risk.

3.3 Information and nudges

This type of policy is designed to make former teachers aware of the options open to them, or simply to ask them to consider a return, through letters, telephone calls, advisers and information sessions. Its core rationale is that many former teachers would consider returning but are not asked, do not know how to do so or expect the process to be burdensome (Section 2). The letter sent by the Minister of Education of Lower Saxony in 2023 acknowledged this explicitly, noting that many teachers about to retire would be willing to teach a few hours a week but were deterred by the bureaucracy involved (Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium, 2023). The approach is present in Austria, England, Japan (depicted in Box 6), Lower Saxony (depicted in Box 4) and New South Wales (depicted in Box 5), and it is among the least expensive instruments available to governments.

Outreach to retired teachers

In December 2022, the education directorate of Vienna (Austria) contacted nearly 300 retired teachers to ask them to return to school, and only three did so. At the end of February 2023 the directorate changed its approach and asked all school principals to consider which of their teachers could be kept on beyond the age of 65 (ORF Wien, 2023). Other Austrian provinces opted for different channels, with Salzburg writing to all retired teachers up to the age of 67 and Vorarlberg sending information on re-entry together with the forms that teachers use to apply for their pension (ORF, 2023). Across the country, only 42 teachers working in the schools run by the provinces in autumn 2022 had been hired at the age of 63 or later (Austrian Parliament, 2023). A study based on interviews with retired teachers who had returned to Austrian schools found that their terms had been negotiated individually with school principals and that none of them would repeat the experience (Resch, 2025). The Austrian case suggests that the timing of the contact and the person who makes it can matter as much as the message itself.

Lower Saxony reached the same conclusion as Vienna and directs its outreach to teachers who are about to retire, combining a personal letter from the minister with financial and administrative changes (Box 4). Quebec has also relied on letters, which the minister sent in June 2023 to ask retired teachers to return for one or two days a week or full-time, and again in August 2025,

when more than 5 000 retirees were already working in schools under the incentives described in Box 3 (Le Devoir, 2025).

Box 4. A combined approach for teachers approaching retirement in Lower Saxony (Germany)

Purpose and origins. Lower Saxony, a federal state of Germany, has combined financial, informational and administrative measures aimed at teachers who are about to retire, as part of a broader set of measures to improve the staffing of its schools. A retired civil-service teacher working for the state used to have the pension reduced once the pension and the new salary together exceeded 125% of the pensionable pay. In October 2022 the state parliament raised this ceiling to 150% for two years, which allowed a pensioner to teach nine to ten lessons a week on average without any reduction, and in October 2024 it abolished the ceiling for teachers who have reached the statutory retirement age, while those who retire early remain subject to it (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2024).

Design and delivery. On 1 November 2023, the Minister of Education wrote to every teacher about to retire, whether a civil servant or a salaried employee, to explain how to continue teaching. A civil servant can ask to postpone retirement by up to three years, and any teacher can be re-employed on a fixed-term contract immediately after retiring while drawing the pension. The letter was addressed to teachers approaching retirement partly because the ministry no longer held the personnel files of those who had already retired, and school principals were also asked to approach these teachers in person (Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium, 2023). A teacher who continues at the same school does not need to apply through the online recruitment system or to provide a new police certificate, and contact persons in each of the four regional school authorities advise retirees and handle the procedure.

Participants and take-up. The number of teachers past retirement age working on fixed-term contracts rose from 229 in 2020 to 437 in 2024 (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2025). According to the ministry, the first contact takes place about six months before retirement, and most returners stay at or return to the school where they last taught, usually part-time and in a specific subject such as mathematics, and rarely as class teachers or formal mentors.

Outcomes, impact and challenges. The funding for these posts must be additional, so that retirees do not take positions from young teachers. The state has no unique teacher identifier with which individual careers could be followed, which limits any assessment of how long returners stay.

Source: Niedersächsischer Landtag (2024), Drucksache 19/5338; Niedersächsischer Landtag (2025), Drucksache 19/8802; Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium (2023), “Schreiben an angehende Pensionärinnen und Pensionäre”; information provided by the Lower Saxony Ministry of Education.

Outreach to recent leavers and licence holders

Outreach has also been directed at teachers who left the profession more recently, particularly where it can be accompanied by practical help and by better working conditions. In November 2023 the education department of New South Wales began to call teachers who had left its schools, offering them help to return at a time when the state was improving the pay of its teachers (Box 5). England has relied instead on a permanent advisory service, through which former teachers can request an adviser who supports them individually with applications, interviews, refresher courses and vacancies. The plan published by the Department for Education in February 2026 to recruit 6 500

additional teachers includes this service among its measures, together with a new step-by-step guide for returners (Department for Education, 2026b).

Japan faces a different situation, because its open licensing system has produced a large pool of people who hold a teaching licence but have never taught or have long been away from schools. Most boards of education now organise information sessions and training for them, with the aim of bringing them into temporary and part-time posts that do not require passing the competitive recruitment examination (Box 6).

Box 5. Outreach to recent leavers in New South Wales (Australia)

Purpose and origins. In November 2023, the Department of Education of New South Wales, an Australian state, began to contact teachers who had left its schools in the previous five years, shortly after the largest pay rise for the state's teachers in decades took effect. The rise, effective from October 2023, raised the starting salary from AUD 75 791 to AUD 85 000 and was accompanied by a reduction in administrative workload (NSW Government, 2023).

Design and delivery. The department contacted more than 1 500 former teachers and asked them to consider returning. Those interested were offered a simpler re-employment process and help with their accreditation, their approval to teach and the working-with-children check, before being placed in casual or temporary work, with permanent posts and small-group tutoring roles also available.

Participants and take-up. By May 2024, more than 260 former teachers had expressed interest and 145 had been matched with schools, about 60% of them returning from retirement (NSW Government, 2024).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. Teacher vacancies in the state fell from a peak of 3 311 in 2022 to 1 294 in February 2025 (NSW Government, 2025), although the contribution of returners to that fall is not known. Because the campaign coincided with better pay and a lighter administrative load, its results cannot be separated from those of the wider improvement in working conditions.

Source: NSW Government (2023), "NSW teachers to receive largest pay rise in decades"; NSW Government (2024), "Retired teachers return to classrooms"; NSW Government (2025), "Teacher vacancies drop under Minns Labor Government".

Box 6. Information sessions for teaching licence holders in Japan

Purpose and origins. In Japan, students at any accredited university can obtain a teaching licence after a practicum of three to four weeks, and many licence holders never teach or leave the profession early, which has produced a large pool of potential teachers. On 1 May 2025, schools were short of 3 827 teachers, against 2 065 in 2021 (MEXT, 2026). The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology (MEXT) encourages boards of education to bring licence holders into schools and funded such initiatives with JPY 500 million in 2024.

Design and delivery. The session organised by the Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education on 15 November 2025 illustrates what licence holders are told. It described a teacher's working day today, team-based pupil guidance, the rest days introduced in club activities and the professional development on offer, and presented the posts available without passing the competitive recruitment examination. Temporary full-time teachers start at JPY 241 900 a month, part-time teachers work up to 680 hours a year at JPY 2 860 an hour, and school support staff work up to 800 hours a year at about JPY 1 000 an hour. The session ended with individual consultations and the registration of participants as temporary teachers, so that the prefecture can call on them when a vacancy appears (Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education, 2025).

Participants and take-up. In 2023, 50 of the 68 prefectural and city boards of education organised sessions or training for licence holders who were not teaching. In Saitama, seven seminars held that year attracted 226 participants, of whom 122 registered for temporary or part-time posts and 53 had been appointed by April 2024, while in Osaka 69 people took part in 2022 and 19 were appointed (MEXT, 2024).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. These sessions are built around the doubts that keep licence holders away from schools, such as the fear of being out of date, the workload and the lack of readiness for a permanent post, and they rely on flexible posts rather than on financial incentives. Results are reported only for a few boards.

Source: MEXT (2024), "Case collection on training for teaching-licence holders not currently teaching"; MEXT (2026), "Results of the survey on the shortage of teachers, fiscal year 2025"; Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education (2025), "Information session on the appeal of teaching", translated by M. Kikuchihara.

Implications for re-entry policies

In most cases the available data do not link returners to the contact that prompted their return, but the figures available suggest that letters sent after retirement drew very few replies. Contact made before retirement, through the school principal or together with help with the procedures, appears more promising, as does outreach to teachers who left recently and can be traced through the employer's records. Information therefore seems most useful when it reaches former teachers while their skills and their links with schools are still intact, and when it comes with measures that make the return easier.

3.4 Support and training

This type of policy is designed to reduce the practical cost of returning through refresher courses, supervised time in classrooms, coaching and induction. Its core rationale is that former teachers who have been away for some years

often doubt that they are still up to date with curricula, assessment and classroom practice, and that schools may share those doubts when they consider their applications. The approach is present in England (depicted in Box 7), Sweden, the canton of Zurich and Victoria (depicted in Box 8), and it is addressed mainly to switchers and leavers, who have usually been away from schools for longer than retired teachers. The evidence on its results is the least encouraging of the five instruments.

Refresher programmes

In England, the Return to Teaching pilot, which in 2016 funded partnerships of schools to support qualified teachers returning to secondary subjects in shortage, attracted far more interest than it could turn into posts, and its evaluation remains the most detailed assessment of a re-entry programme available (Box 7). The Department for Education followed it with the Returners Engagement Programme, which between November 2016 and March 2018 funded lead schools in two regions to offer returners in mathematics, physics and modern foreign languages a course of two to four weeks that included teaching practice. Support was tied to identified vacancies, schools received GBP 1 500 for each returner they employed and returners could claim up to GBP 600 to cover childcare or travel, until the programme was withdrawn (Department for Education, 2016).

In October 2018 Sweden's National Agency for Education launched a free online course for teachers and preschool teachers returning to the profession, which covered the changes in curricula, legislation and guidelines introduced since the reforms of 2010 and 2011. By April 2020, 1 018 people had registered, 175 had completed at least one module and only 38 had completed the whole course. About one-third of the respondents to a follow-up survey were actually returning teachers, and none of those already employed had been given working time, a mentor or a study group to take the course. With a cost of SEK 17 268 per participant, against SEK 863 for a comparable online course, the agency concluded that the course had not reached its target group (Skolverket, 2020).

Box 7. The Return to Teaching pilot in England (United Kingdom)

Purpose and origins. Between January and October 2016, the Department for Education funded 60 partnerships of schools to support qualified teachers returning to secondary subjects in shortage, with a target of 3 000 registrations.

Design and delivery. The support was free for the returner and covered subject knowledge, updates on assessment and behaviour management, classroom experience and mentoring, delivered by the schools in each partnership.

Participants and take-up. The pilot attracted 5 729 registrations, but only 354 registrants received support, and by November 2016, 62 of them were teaching in a state school and 27 held a permanent post in the targeted subjects. The cost per additional returner was about GBP 37 400, close to the cost of training a new teacher, and the independent evaluation judged the pilot unlikely to represent good value for money (Buchanan et al., 2018).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. The evaluation identified several reasons why so few registrants returned. Support began in January, when few posts for the following September remained open, and many schools hesitated to give returners teaching practice, citing the need to establish their quality and the risk of disrupting lessons, with the result that only 44% of returners felt that their needs had been met. Half of the returners and schools interviewed reported that returners were looking for part-time work, which few schools offered. Interest in returning was therefore not the binding constraint, since most of the losses occurred at the later stages, when support had to turn into a post.

Source: Buchanan, E. et al. (2018), *Evaluation of the Return to Teaching Pilot Programme*.

Induction and placements in schools

Programmes that build the return into the school itself appear more promising, although none of them has been evaluated. In the canton of Zurich (Switzerland), teachers who return after eight years or more away are entitled during their first year back to the same induction programme as new teachers, free of charge, including up to 25 hours of mentoring by a trained colleague in their own school, group supervision and subject coaching. Returners can also obtain an individual assessment of the preparation they need, of which the canton pays the first hour and the teacher the rest, although the university of teacher education that provides this assessment was not offering counselling to returners in October 2026 (PH Zürich, 2026). In Victoria, former teachers are paid to spend several weeks in a school, observing and teaching with the guidance of serving staff, before they apply for a post (Box 8).

Box 8. Paid school placements for former teachers in Victoria (Australia)

Purpose and origins. Victoria, an Australian state, launched its Teacher Re-Engagement Initiative in late 2022 to help qualified teachers who had left the profession to return to government schools.

Design and delivery. Registered teachers who have been away from teaching for at least 12 months are offered a paid placement of up to 40 days in a government school, during which they observe classes and school routines and are mentored by serving staff, before they apply for a post. A central team matches participants with schools according to their subject, experience, location and availability, and records at the end of the placement whether the participant has returned to teaching.

Participants and take-up. The initiative attracted more than 1 100 expressions of interest and received AUD 12 million in the 2023/24 state budget (Victorian Government, 2023). It is now funded by the schools that host a returner, at a cost of AUD 330 a day that covers the participant's honorarium and the administrative costs (Victorian Government, 2026).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. No figures have been published on the number of participants who went on to teach. A supervised placement responds at the same time to the returner's lack of confidence and to the school's uncertainty about the returner, the two obstacles identified in England (Box 7), but shifting its cost to schools may limit its use to those that can afford it.

Source: Victorian Government (2023), "Ensuring a strong, sustainable and supported school workforce"; Victorian Government (2026), "Teacher Re-Engagement Initiative".

Implications for re-entry policies

The English and Swedish experiences indicate that support detached from schools and from vacancies attracts interest but produces few returns, whereas the programmes of Zurich and Victoria place the returner in a school from the start. Support of this kind is more likely to lead to returns when it follows the recruitment calendar, is tied to real posts and includes time in front of a class, and when schools are willing to offer the part-time positions that many returners want.

3.5 Flexible positions

This type of policy offers former teachers roles other than a full-time teaching post, such as relief teaching, which provides short-term cover for absent teachers, adjunct teaching, tutoring and mentoring. Its core rationale is that many former teachers would come back to schools, but not to a full-time post. As discussed in Section 2, leavers with care responsibilities and retirees often prefer to work only part of the week, and half of the returners and schools interviewed in the evaluation of the English pilot reported a demand for part-time work that few schools were able to meet (Buchanan et al., 2018). The approach is present in the Bahamas, China (depicted in Box 10), Singapore (depicted in Box 9), Spain and the United States (depicted in Box 11), and it also allows education systems to use the experience of former teachers where it is most valuable.

Pools of flexible teachers

Several systems keep a standing pool of former teachers whom schools can call on when they need them, as Singapore has done since 2004 (Box 9). In July 2026 the Bahamas announced a similar reserve of former teachers, retirees and recent graduates, built on its existing platform for supply teachers, as part of a recruitment drive to fill about 300 vacancies in 162 public schools spread over 24 islands. A task force of several government agencies checks the records and accreditation of candidates to allow them to start quickly, and by September 2026 more than 100 teachers had been recruited through the drive and about 100 more were being vetted (Ministry of Education of The Bahamas, 2026; ZNS Bahamas, 2026). The rules on combining a pension with a salary described in Section 3.2, such as those of Ireland and Ontario, also create in practice a pool of retired substitutes. China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan follows a different logic. It sends returners for a whole school year to schools far from where they used to work and gives them an explicit role in developing the young teachers of those schools (Box 10).

Box 9. A standing pool of adjunct teachers in Singapore

Purpose and origins. Singapore's Ministry of Education launched an adjunct teachers programme in 2004 to attract trained former teachers back to the profession on more flexible terms.

Design and delivery. Under the current Flexi-Adjunct Teaching Scheme, former teachers register on a ministry portal for three years, and schools contact them directly for appointments of one day to ten weeks, either for teaching alone or for teaching combined with other duties agreed with the school. Adjunct teachers are paid by the hour, at rates that depend on their experience, and earn leave once they have accumulated 90 days of service, while former teachers of the ministry must have performed well in their last three years of service to join (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2026a). A companion programme offers former ministry teachers contracts of one to one and a half years, full-time or part-time (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2026b).

Participants and take-up. Between 2022 and 2024, about 220 teachers a year joined the programme within 12 months of leaving the service. In the same period, the annual resignation rate of teachers was 2.4%, or 1.7% if those who joined the programme are excluded (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2025a; 2025b).

Outcomes, impact and challenges. The programme keeps the system in contact with teachers at the moment they leave, before their skills and their links with schools fade. Pay at the highest rate is below 60% of the median pay package of a classroom teacher (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2024), which keeps the programme inexpensive but limits its use to occasional cover.

Source: Ministry of Education Singapore (2024; 2025a; 2025b), parliamentary replies; Ministry of Education Singapore (2026a), "Flexi-Adjunct Teaching Scheme"; Ministry of Education Singapore (2026b), "Contract Adjunct Teaching Scheme".

Box 10. Retired teachers in rural schools in China

Purpose and origins. China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan was launched in 2018 by the Ministries of Education and Finance to strengthen rural primary and lower secondary schools in poor, ethnic minority and border counties with the experience of retired teachers.

Design and delivery. The plan recruits retired principals, teaching researchers and senior teachers, generally aged 65 or under, to serve for at least a school year in these schools, and returning to one's own former school is not allowed. Participants teach classes, observe lessons and give demonstration lessons, coach the young teachers of the school and help with its management, and since 2024 retired principals may serve as deputy heads. They keep their pension and receive CNY 20 000 a year to cover living costs, travel and insurance, an amount paid by the central government in western provinces, shared between central and provincial governments in central provinces and paid by the provinces themselves in the east (Ministry of Education and Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China, 2018).

Participants and take-up. The first plan set a target of 10 000 places for the period 2018 to 2020, and more than 20 000 retired teachers had been recruited to primary and secondary schools by mid-2023 (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2023). Recent annual rounds have planned between 6 000 and 7 000 places.

Outcomes, impact and challenges. The 2026 round places the coaching of young teachers at the centre of the role and introduces an assessment by the host school at the end of each placement (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2026), which may provide the first systematic information on the results of the plan.

Source: Ministry of Education and Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China (2018), Jiaoshi [2018] No. 7; Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China (2023; 2026).

Mentoring and tutoring

Mentoring and tutoring by retired teachers are the uses of former teachers that have been tested most rigorously. Three randomised trials in the United States, presented in Box 11, found positive effects on pupils' learning, which were small in the case of retired teachers mentoring new teachers and larger in the case of tutoring for pupils who were falling behind. These results are consistent with the broader experimental evidence on tutoring cited in Section 1 (Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024), and suggest that tutoring is one of the most productive uses of former teachers who do not wish to return to a full teaching post. Smaller initiatives point in the same direction. In 2018, ten retired early childhood and primary teachers mentored 57 student teachers at the University of Zaragoza in the final years of their degree, meeting each group three times to discuss the profession, further training and the teaching career, and 56% of the students who answered a survey said that the sessions had helped them to orient their careers (Lizalde Gil and Cortés Pascual, 2019).

Box 11. Experimental evidence on retired teachers as mentors and tutors in the United States

Mentoring new teachers. In 2013/14 and 2014/15, recently retired teachers and principals mentored teachers in their first three years in 11 high-poverty elementary schools of Aurora, Colorado. Mentors were paid USD 41 an hour and met each new teacher for about an hour a week over two years. A randomised trial of 77 teachers compared them with the usual support of the district, provided by a colleague who received a small stipend. Pupils of mentored teachers gained 0.064 standard deviations in mathematics after the first year, about one month of learning, and the effect was of similar size after the second year but no longer statistically significant. The trial found no effect on reading or on the retention of the new teachers (DeCesare et al., 2017).

Tutoring in mathematics. In 76 schools of four urban districts, first graders with weak number skills received about 30 hours of small-group tutoring over 17 weeks. Most of the 86 tutors were retired or substitute teachers, hired through a temporary staffing company and trained for one day, with two short follow-up sessions. In a randomised trial of 994 pupils, tutored pupils outperformed their peers by an effect size of 0.34 (Gersten et al., 2015).

Tutoring in reading. AARP Foundation Experience Corps trains volunteers aged 50 and over, among them former teachers, to tutor children to read well by the end of grade 3. In 2023/24, 1 284 volunteers worked with 3 659 children in 18 communities (AARP Foundation, 2026). A randomised evaluation in 23 schools in Boston, New York City and Port Arthur found gains in reading comprehension, with effect sizes of 0.13 to 0.17 for pupils who attended 35 sessions or more (Morrow-Howell et al., 2009).

Source: DeCesare, D., A. McClelland and B. Randel (2017), *Impacts of the Retired Mentors for New Teachers Program*; Gersten, R. et al. (2015); Morrow-Howell, N. et al. (2009), *Evaluation of Experience Corps*; AARP Foundation (2026).

Implications for re-entry policies

The experience with flexible positions shows that they reach former teachers who would not return to a full post, and particularly retirees and leavers with care responsibilities. Their value for pupils depends on the role assigned to returners, as the largest benefits observed come from tutoring, and their cost depends on the pay offered. Singapore keeps its pool inexpensive by paying adjunct teachers well below regular teachers, but this also limits the use of the pool to occasional cover, whereas China and the tutoring programmes assign returners a defined role over a whole school year.

3.6 Flexible re-certification

This type of policy lowers the regulatory requirements that a former teacher must meet to teach again. Its core rationale is that, although licensing requirements play a minor part in the decision to leave teaching (Section 2), a teacher who has been away for several years may need to renew a lapsed licence or complete a refresher programme before teaching again, a process that can take months and involve costs precisely when a school is waiting to fill a post. The approach is present in New Zealand (depicted in Box 12) and Virginia, and in lighter forms in several of the policies described in previous sections.

New Zealand has replaced its refresher programme with a plan agreed between the returner and the principal of the school that offers the job (Box 12). In the United States, Virginia's Executive Directive 3 of September 2022 instructed the state's licensing authority to issue licences to retired teachers whose licences had lapsed, and the state launched an online licensing system in November 2023 (Commonwealth of Virginia, 2022). Other policies include lighter versions of the same instrument. New South Wales helped returners to renew their accreditation (Box 5), Lower Saxony exempts teachers who continue at their school immediately after retiring from providing a new police certificate or applying through the online recruitment system (Box 4), and the task force set up in the Bahamas checks the records and accreditation of recruits (Section 3.5).

Box 12. A school-based return-to-practice plan in New Zealand

Purpose and origins. To renew a practising certificate, a teacher in New Zealand must have at least two years of satisfactory teaching in the previous five. Teachers who did not meet this requirement used to complete an external refresher programme, the Teacher Education Refresh, before returning. Since September 2024, the Teaching Council has allowed returners with a job offer to replace it with a return-to-practice plan, and in December 2025 it made this route permanent from January 2026 under the name Kia Maia (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2025).

Design and delivery. The returner assesses, together with the principal of the school that has offered the job, what has changed since they last taught, and the plan lists at least three resources for each professional standard that the returner will use during the first 12 months back. Both sign the plan, which Council staff review without assessing the teacher's competence, and the certificate is then renewed. Without a job offer, the refresher programme is still likely to be required (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2026). The government also paid the registration fees of returning teachers from October 2024, supporting 352 returners by April 2025, and has covered the fees of all teachers since July 2025 with NZD 53.3 million over three years (Ministry of Education New Zealand, 2025).

Participants and take-up. Between January and October 2026, 501 teachers renewed their certificate through Kia Maia, most of them working in primary (198) or secondary (133) schools or in early childhood education (110). Women made up 84% of users and 62% were aged 31 to 50, while only 16% were aged 61 or over (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, unpublished), which indicates that the pathway mainly brings back mid-career teachers who had stepped away from the profession.

Outcomes, impact and challenges. Linking the renewal of the certificate to a job offer removes a cost and a delay at the moment when the returner is ready to start, and it involves the principal in the returner's first year, which the evidence on induction and leadership reviewed in Section 2 suggests is important for whether returners stay.

Source: Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand (2025), "Introducing Kia Maia"; Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand (2026), "Renew after time away"; Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand (unpublished), data on Kia Maia users; Ministry of Education New Zealand (2025).

Implications for re-entry policies

The New Zealand data show who uses the new route but not whether its users would have returned through the refresher programme. Estimating the effect of the reform would require comparable data collected before and after it. The instrument nonetheless has a practical appeal for systems with demanding renewal rules, because it acts at the point where a returner who has already found a post could still be lost.

3.7 Summary of the review

Overall, the policies reviewed respond mostly to shortages, are addressed mainly to retired teachers and have rarely been evaluated. Box 13 sets out what each instrument suggests for the design of re-entry policies.

Box 13. What the policies reviewed teach us about re-attracting former teachers

Each instrument responds to a barrier identified in Section 2, and the policies with the most encouraging results combine several of them.

Financial incentives. *Mainly retired teachers.* Changing the rules on combining a pension with a salary is inexpensive and brings back experienced teachers, mostly to the schools where they used to work. Waiting periods, eligibility rules and the posts covered determine the reach of these rules as much as the incentive itself, and payments to schools risk rewarding hires that would have taken place anyway.

Information and nudges. *All profiles.* Letters sent after retirement draw very few replies. Contact before retirement or soon after leaving, made through the principal and accompanied by help with the procedures, appears more effective, particularly when it coincides with better working conditions.

Support and training. *Mainly switchers and leavers.* Refresher courses detached from schools and vacancies attract interest but few returns. Support leads to returns when it follows the recruitment calendar, is tied to real posts and includes supervised time in front of a class.

Flexible positions. *All profiles.* Pools of relief and adjunct teachers bring back those who would not return to a full post, and the strongest evidence of benefits for pupils in this review concerns retired teachers working as tutors and mentors.

Flexible re-certification. *Mainly switchers and leavers.* Linking the renewal of a licence to a job offer and to a plan agreed with the school removes a cost and a delay at the moment of return, and involves the principal in the returner's first year.

Overall. Most policies are short-term remedies for local shortages, and few have been evaluated or allow returners to be followed over time. Combining instruments, reaching teachers at the right moment and offering roles that match their preferences appear to matter more than the size of any single incentive, and building evaluation and data on returners into new policies would allow systems to learn which of them work.

4. Conclusions

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